

Program: _____ Center: _____

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Making a mistake at work!



Describe hypothetical situations in spoken interactions according to work and social contexts.

- Have you ever made a big mistake? What mistake did you make?
- Do you think you are good at meeting deadlines? Why or why not?

- I can talk about reactions and behavior in a work situation.
- I can quote other people.
- I can react to things going wrong and talk about hypothetical situations about the past.



Let's Explore!

Sally tells Vanessa that she **screwed up***.

* "To screw up" is a slang term for make a mistake.



Instructions: Read the text aloud.

- Sally:** Hello?
- Vanessa:** Hey, Sally! How's it going?
- Sally:** I'm really upset! I got chewed out at work yesterday. My boss said I wasn't very conscientious.
- Vanessa:** Oh no! What happened?
- Sally:** It was my fault. I should have confirmed the deadline time. I handed in my blog assignment late. I feel really guilty. I should have asked what she meant by "end of the day".
- Vanessa:** Did you tell her it was a misunderstanding? She could have been more specific about what she meant by "end of the day".
- Sally:** We talked about improving our communication.
- Vanessa:** Good. I'm sure she knows that you would have submitted your work on time if you had been certain of the time. You're always punctual and meticulous.
- Sally:** She was quite aggressive in her tone of voice. I said I was really sorry. I know I'm sensitive sometimes and I screwed up, but I think she overreacted.
- Vanessa:** Well, maybe she was having a bad day, but she shouldn't have taken it out on you. It's not professional but it happens to everyone.
- Sally:** She did say that she was feeling overwhelmed. It's been really busy at the magazine.
- Vanessa:** Well, you explained that you had made a mistake and you apologized. To avoid these misunderstandings just make sure you always communicate clearly, and you'll be fine.
- Sally:** Thanks, Vanessa!

**Let's Practice!**

There were a number of conversations at the magazine. What was said?

Instructions: Complete the sentences by choosing from the words that you are given.

Word Bank

- that you had
- have asked
- said I wasn't
- say that she was
- said I was really

- 1) My boss _____ very conscientious.
- 2) I should _____ what she meant by "end of the day".
- 3) Well, you explained _____ made a mistake and you apologized.
- 4) I _____ sorry.
- 5) She did _____ feeling overwhelmed. It's been really busy at the magazine.

**Let's Practice!**

Vanessa and Sally discuss what could have been done or said to make the situation better.

Instructions: Read the sentences below and circle the incorrect words.

- 1) I should have confirming the deadline time.
- 2) I should has asked what she meant by "end of the day".
- 3) She can have been more specific about what she meant by "end of the day".
- 4) Good. I'm sure she knows that you should have submitted your work on time if you had been certain of the time.
- 5) Well, maybe she was having a bad day, but she shouldn't have taking it out on you.





Extension Activity

Everyone makes mistakes.

Instructions: Complete the following steps. Fill in the Self-Assessment.

- Imagine that you made a mistake at work.
- Write an e-mail to your boss explaining what happened, apologizing and telling him or her how you will prevent it from happening again.
- Be sure to use language to express hypothetical situations in the past.
- Exchange your e-mail with a partner and give your partner feedback on his or her e-mail.

Self-Assessment

Yes

No

I talk about reactions and behavior in a work situation.

☐ ☐

I use reported speech.

☐ ☐

I react to things going wrong and talk about hypothetical situations about the past.

☐ ☐

I write an e-mail explaining a mistake and apologizing.

☐ ☐


Target Words

- **to chew someone out** (expression): to scold someone
e.g. I got chewed out at work yesterday.
- **conscientious** (adjective): concerned with doing something correctly
e.g. My boss said I wasn't very conscientious.
- **specific** (adjective): special or particular
e.g. She could have been more specific.
- **communication** (noun): the act or process of using words, sounds, signs, or behaviors to express or exchange information
e.g. We talked about improving our communication.
- **meticulous** (adjective): very careful about doing something in an exact way
e.g. You're always punctual and meticulous.
- **tone of voice** (expression): the quality of a person's voice
e.g. She was quite aggressive in her tone of voice.
- **to take it out on someone** (expression): direct your anger or frustration at a particular person
e.g. She shouldn't have taken it out on you.
- **professional** (adjective): relating to a job that requires special education, training, or skill
e.g. It's not professional but it happens to everyone.





Learning Points

Reported Speech and Questions

You use reported speech when you are saying (reporting) what other people said.

When you tell people what someone has said in the past, you need to change the verb to a tense further back in time.

Direct Speech	Reported Speech
"I like him."	He said he liked him.
"I'm coming to the party."	He said he was coming .
"I already ate ."	He said he had already eaten .
"I can cook."	He told me he could cook.
"Where do you live ?"	He asked me where I lived .

You have to change the pronoun if you are reporting what someone else said. Compare these two sentences. In each case the person actually said "I don't want to go."

- I said, "I don't want to go." > I said **I** didn't want to go.
- Bill said, "I don't want to go." > Bill said **he** didn't want to go.

Look at the chart below to see the changes in verb tense.

Direct Speech	Reported Speech
Simple Present	Simple Past
Present Progressive	Past Progressive
Simple Past	Past Perfect
Present Perfect	Past Perfect
Past Progressive	Past Perfect Progressive
Future Simple (will)	Conditional (would)
Modal <i>can</i>	Modal <i>could</i>
Modal <i>may</i>	Modal <i>might</i>
Modal <i>will</i>	Modal <i>would</i>





Learning Points

Examples:

- *My boss said I wasn't very conscientious.*
- *I said I was really sorry.*
- *She did say that she was feeling overwhelmed.*
- *You explained that you had made a mistake.*

Talking Hypothetically About the Past

You use *could have*, *should have* and *would have* to talk about things that were possible in the past and may or may not have happened.

The structure:

Subject + modal verb + have + verb (past participle)

I could have done

You should have made

She would have said

You use *could have* to talk about possibilities if something had been different in the past.
For example: *She could have been more specific.*

You use *should have* to talk about past events that did not happen and to speculate about events that may or may not have happened.

For example: *I should have confirmed the deadline time.*

You use *should not have* to speculate negatively about what may or may not have happened.

You also use *should not have* to express regret for past actions.

You use *would have* to imagine a result if something had been different in the past.

For example: *You would have submitted your work on time if you had been certain of the time.*

* *Would have* expresses more certainty about the result than *could have*.

Examples:

- *I should have confirmed the deadline time.*
- *She could have been more specific about what she meant by "end of the day".*
- *You would have submitted your work on time if you had been certain of the time.*
- *She shouldn't have taken it out on you.*

